

Nikaō

νικάω

nikaō – to overcome, to conquer, to win. Strong's G3528.

In ordinary Greek, *nikaō* is the word for winning. An army wins a battle. An athlete wins a race. Someone wins a case in court. It is the verb behind *nikē*, victory.

The New Testament uses the verb 28 times. Twenty-four of those are in John's writings: once in his gospel, six times in his first letter, and seventeen times in Revelation. So if we want to know what overcoming means in the New Testament, John is the one to ask.

The English hides this a little. The ESV usually says “overcome” in John's gospel and letter, and “conquer” in Revelation. It is the same word.

WHERE JESUS IS THE SUBJECT

“In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world” (John 16:33).

Jesus says this on the night before the cross. He does not say the trouble will not come. He says it will. Then he says he has already overcome the world, before the arrest, the trial and the nails.

In Revelation, John is told: “Behold, the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has conquered.” He turns to look at the lion, and sees “a

Lamb standing, as though it had been slain” (Revelation 5:5–6). The one who conquered is the one who was killed.

WHERE BELIEVERS ARE THE SUBJECT

In 1 John, the young men “have overcome the evil one,” and the reason given is that “the word of God abides in you” (2:14). They have overcome false teachers “for he who is in you is greater than he who is in the world” (4:4). Then: “this is the victory that has overcome the world—our faith” (5:4). In John’s letter, overcoming is about believing and trusting, not about what happens to you.

Each of the seven letters in Revelation 2 and 3 ends with a promise to “the one who conquers.” The letter to Smyrna says what that will take: “Do not fear what you are about to suffer... Be faithful unto death, and I will give you the crown of life” (2:10). The last of the seven ties the believer’s conquering to Jesus’ own: “The one who conquers, I will grant him to sit with me on my throne, as I also conquered and sat down with my Father on his throne” (3:21).

THE SAME WORD, BOTH WAYS

Twice in Revelation, the beast conquers the saints. It “will make war on them and conquer them and kill them” (11:7). “It was allowed to make war on the saints and to conquer them” (13:7).

And the saints conquer the beast. “They have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death” (12:11). Later John sees “those who had conquered

the beast,” standing beside the sea of glass with harps in their hands (15:2).

The beast conquers them by killing them. They conquer the beast by staying faithful while they are killed. John uses one verb for both.

PAUL

Paul uses the verb three times, all in Romans. One is about God being in the right when he is judged (3:4). Two are in one verse: “Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good” (12:21). There, the way to overcome evil is to do good to the person doing it.

He also uses a stronger form once. After a list of “tribulation, or distress, or persecution, or famine, or nakedness, or danger, or sword,” and the words “we are being killed all the day long,” Paul says: “No, in all these things we are more than conquerors through him who loved us” (Romans 8:35–37). The word is *hupernikaō*, to win completely. Paul says “in all these things,” not “out of all these things.”

VICTORY

The noun for victory, *nikos*, appears four times. Three are at the end of 1 Corinthians 15: “Death is swallowed up in victory... O death, where is your victory?... thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ” (15:54–57). The last enemy is death, and the victory over it comes at the resurrection.

The fourth is in Matthew, quoting Isaiah about the servant of the Lord: “a bruised reed he will not break, and a smoldering wick he will not quench,

until he brings justice to victory” (Matthew 12:20). Even here, the one who wins is gentle with the weak.

IN SHORT

In the New Testament, overcoming is real. Jesus has overcome the world, and the believer is promised a share in his victory. But the victory is his kind of victory. It was won on a cross, and it is shared by those who stay faithful, even unto death.

This article did not begin with artificial intelligence. It began with years of ministry, reading, prayer, suffering, and conversation.

During its development, AI became a conversation partner. It challenged assumptions, tested arguments, suggested structures, and helped refine expression. Many of the words here emerged through that dialogue.

The experiences, convictions, interpretations, and conclusions remain my own.